

greatest men of antiquity, and an unsurpassed creation of religious philosophy and poetry, without blemish or ambiguity. While the transforming touches remain, the 'prophet' is a forlorn figure, and his work is *tohu* and *bohu*. Confusion and incoherence are substituted for order and logical consistency, very extensive interpolation and editorial adjustment must be supposed, and the whole work is largely emptied of ethical value. Its second half (a succession of magnificent poems!) is of necessity ascribed to an inferior imitator, or to a school of imitators, no one of whom clearly understood either his own message or that of the predecessors whose phrases and figures of speech he copied.*

It is now in place to examine the Hebrew text of the passages which contain mention of the foreign king by name and evident reference to Babylonia as the land to be conquered by him and thereupon to be abandoned by Jewish exiles returning to Jerusalem. The ancient versions support the Hebrew; no argument against the traditional reading can be derived from any one of them, in any of the passages to be considered. If the original text has suffered alteration or received addition, the 'improvement' was made before the time when the work of translation into Greek was undertaken. There is, however, other and most important evidence, quite aside from the general literary considerations. The *meter* of the poems affords a criterion of which the value is universally recognized.

Emendation on the basis of metric form is now a commonplace of textual criticism, and wherever meter and internal evidence plainly support each other against the traditional reading the argument is justly regarded as conclusive. There is need of great caution here (see Chapter X), but valid evidence is to be had. Very many passages in the poetical portions of the Hebrew Bible have thus been restored to their original form, with the approval of all competent scholars. The Hebrew text of II Isaiah is generally well preserved, a fact which is of great assistance in an investigation of this nature. The present problem, moreover, is in fact simpler than appears at first sight. It can easily be shown that the whole question of the interpolation of Babylonian-exilic allusions hangs upon the single word *lē-Kōresh*, "to Cyrus," in 45:1. On this depends also the decision as to the meaning and value of the prophecy of the Second Isaiah. If the prophet himself wrote here

* If the reader supposes this to be an exaggerated statement, it is only necessary to refer him to any one of the modern standard commentaries. See also the concluding section of Chapter I in this volume.